

134. When they meet each other in the streets, you may know if the persons meeting are of equal rank by the following token ; if they are, instead of speaking, they kiss each other on the lips. In the case where one is a little inferior to the other, the kiss is given on the cheek ; where the difference of rank is great, the inferior prostrates himself upon the ground.² Of nations, they honour most their nearest neighbours whom they esteem next to themselves ; those who live beyond these they honour in the second degree ; and so with the remainder, the further they are removed, the less the esteem in which they hold them. The reason is, that they look upon themselves as very greatly superior in all respects to the rest of mankind, regarding others as approaching to excellence in proportion as they dwell nearer to them ;³ whence it comes to pass that those who are the farthest off must be the most degraded of mankind.⁴ Under the dominion of the Medes, the several nations of the empire exer-

and war under the influence of wine, reserving their determination for the morrow. He gives the reasons for the practice, of which he manifestly approves :—"De pace denique et bello plerumque in conviviis consultant, tanquam nullo magis tempore ad magnas cogitationes incalescat animus. Gens non astuta, nec callida, aperit adhuc secreta pectoris, licentiâ joci. Ergò detecta et nuda omnium mens, posterâ die retractatur ; et salva utriusque temporis ratio est. Deliberant, dum fingere nesciunt : constituunt, dum errare non possunt."—(Germ. 22.) It does not appear that the Germans reversed the process.

Plato, in his *Laws*, mentions the use made of drunkenness by the Persians. He says, the same practice obtained among the Thracians, the Scythians, the Celts, the Iberians, and the Carthaginians (*Book 1. p. 637, E*). Duris of Samos declared that once a year, at the feast of Mithras, the king of Persia was bound to be drunk. (*Fr. 13.*)

² The Persians are still notorious for their rigid attention to ceremonial and etiquette. In all the ordinary pursuits of life, paying visits, entering a room, seating oneself in company, in epistolary address, and even in conversational idiom, gradations of rank are defined with equal strictness and nicety. With regard to the method of salutation, the extreme limits are, as Herodotus observes, the mutual embrace (the kiss is now invariably given on the cheek), and prostration on the ground ; but there are also several intermediate forms, which he has not thought it worth while to notice, of obeisance, kissing hands, &c., by which an experienced observer learns the exact relation of the parties.—[H. C. R.]

³ Of late years, since the nations of Europe have been brought by their commercial and political relations into closer connection with Persia, the excessive vanity and self-admiration of these Frenchmen of the East has been somewhat abated. Their monarch, however, still retains the title of "the Centre of the Universe," and it is not easy to persuade a native of Isfahan that any European capital can be superior to his native city.—[H. C. R.]

⁴ In an early stage of geographical knowledge each nation regards itself as occupying the centre of the earth. Herodotus tacitly assumes that Greece is the centre by his theory of *ἐσχάραι* or "extremities" (iii. 115). Such was the view commonly entertained among the Greeks, and Delphi, as the centre of Greece, was called "the navel of the world" (*γᾶς ὀμφαλός*, Soph. *Œd. T.* 898 ; Pind. *Pyth.* vi. 3, &c.). Even Aristotle expresses himself to the same effect, and regards the happy temperament of the Greeks as the result of their intermediate position (*Polit.* vii. 6). Our own use of the terms "*the East*," "*the West*," is a trace of the former existence of similar views among ourselves.